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An Ageing Emperor’s Interventions

WHEN ASHOKA SET DOWN STRICTURES AGAINST schismatic monks and nuns, he had been reigning for some thirty years. It appears that as he reached middle age and before positioning himself as a regulator of the faith, he resumed communicating with his subjects at large in the familiar mode begun a dozen years earlier. Around 243 BCE, a set of six edicts elucidating his policies and ideas was inscribed. This compilation, like the major rock edicts, was put up in multiple places though not on natural rock: it was engraved on pillars. Speaking in the first person, Ashoka picks up from where he had left off. He appears consumed by the need to bring the people of his realm to greater virtue. The intervening years—from the time when the major rock edicts were inscribed to the engraving of these pillar edicts—had altered his perception of the endeavour to promote morality rooted in dhamma. Consequently, he tweaks his policies in line with the changed viewpoint.

The pillars are mainly across a fairly large part of North India. They were set up roughly in the north Bihar segment of the Gangetic plains—at Lauriya-Araraj, Lauriya-Nandangarh, and Rampurva. Eastwards, a pillar with a similar message stands at Allahabad, which, as noted, was possibly originally located at Kaushambi. As their positioning on the Allahabad pillar makes evident, the edicts on them may have been engraved before the king’s proscription against schisms. The long pillar edicts were for his subjects as a whole, not for members of any specific religious community. Moving along the Ganga, further west, in the vicinity of Meerut, this set of six edicts (later brought to Delhi by Sultan Firuz Shah Tughlaq) was put up